Rain in the Rotten City

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Mature

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F/F, F/M

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
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by Jezmatron

Summary

Adora's gone missing. Not so surprising given the city of Freiburg is a scab on the sore of the world. A place of broken dreams and broken people. Where angels cry, and love is a dirty word. Where justice gave up long ago.

What's a girl to do when the dame she's wanted for years vanishes? Every story worth telling is about a dame. About pride. About the fall.

Come walk these dirty streets that even the rain can't wash clean.

Notes

Thought I'd try something NEW.

A bit of a purple prose detective yarn one shot.

First time doing First person present tense, so do feel free to leave feedback! Some MINOR OOC actions (You'll see) buuuut kind of makes sense in context. I hope you like!

Like all stories worth telling, this one's about a dame. You know how it goes: seedy streets, girl in trouble, the noble hero ridin' to the rescue.

Well, I ain't no hero. Been a villain longer than I care to remember, but managed to drag myself out of that gutter, with some help. Considered crawling right back in with a bottle of liquor only fit to be paintstripper, but that help held on tight and wouldn't let me take the easy way out. Wouldn't let me forget on those dark nights when I wanted to wish it all away, like smoke in a streetlight.

Now I'm a *respectable* citizen. Even got a new career. It's like my old career, but without the kickbacks coming my way. Real glamorous too - I have my own office, a desk, even a fancy lamp.

I am, as some of the kids straight off the ferry say, "living the dream."

If that's the case, ol' Mister Sandman owes me big time.

But back to the story. Like I said, it's about a dame. Not me, of course, though I do play a pretty big role, y'know, tootin' my own horn here. How could I not?

I remember the day it started. It was raining. Then again, it's always raining in Freiburg. *Tears of the angels* , the happier

drunks call it. Now, whether they're grieving our sorry lot or laughing at the schmucks being taken for a dollar a ride is anyone's guess. Me, I'd bet on laughing any day of the week. Either way, all I know is that it was raining when she walked in: all glitter and a glare that could kill.

She and I went way back, of course. If Scorpia had been working that day she probably wouldn't have gotten through the door. Scorpia's a doll. My best friend. My saviour. And my biggest pain in the ass. Well, one of them anyway.

She's a good kid, but a heart too kind for the city. It's why she and I, well, we never got too far. Well, it's *one* of the reasons why.

Like I said, this story's about a dame.

So, short, angry and glittery stalks into my office like she owns the place. Given her family, that might not have been far from the truth. A shame Scorpia was out with her squeeze at some fancy joint, as I wasn't in the mood for scintillating conversation. I had a date with a bottle and a clear appointment book. Sleep comes hard, y'know, when you have the memories I do. The guilt of a thousand bad decisions, all traced back to one bad day.

"Catra," her voice was like unoiled brakes - insistent, jarring and a shock on a dark night. I felt all ready to stand up and go swinging, but I'd just had the shirt cleaned.

“Sparkles, slummin’ it with the common crowd? Done playing dancer?”

Who was she? Gloria “Glimmer” Moon. Daughter to a major city counsellor. One of the few *good* ones, Counsellor Angella Moon. Of course, good is a mixed bag in a city as dank as Freiburg. You don’t kick a man when he’s down, practically gets you a key to the city. But I’d give the woman her due - she tried.

“I...we need your help Catra.”

“What, tall blonde and *traitorous* doesn’t have the guts to come see me?” Now, see, I knew I was being unfair. Just adding to that pile of regrets. They say pride will kill a gal before a bullet. And well, I’m nothing if not prideful.

“She’s gone.”

Sometimes you hear words that are like a block of ice in your gut. You imagine them. Play them around, like playing with an open wound, just to see if you can handle the pain. Like touching a match after it’s burnt out. But when you stick your hand in a real fire, you realise you weren’t ready.

“What do you mean?”

Glimmer’s face was a mask of pain. You could smell the fear rolling off her, like brine down the docks. I’ve known Glimmer since before this shitty job, this halfway house between failure and the chance at redemption. I watched her, half suspecting a setup, another attempt to reach out. I was half ready to throw her out, toss the bottle at her too, for good measure. But I also wanted to beg, to scream that *she* wasn’t gone. Dread is an emotion I’m familiar with - doesn’t mean I like it.

“She never turned up for her show last night. Down at the Salineas?”

“Misty’s place?” another mistake. Or almost one - remember the phrase “Never kiss crazy”? It's one I’ve stuck to over the years. Doesn’t mean i didn’t nearly dabble, just to get a reaction from *her* , of course.

“Yeah. Even when you tried rockin’ that boat, Adora put up with it. She knew you were hurtin’. And, well, she wanted you happy, Catra.”

That got a glare right back in her sparkling face. I don’t do pity. Hate it. Another reason for that mistake, but like I said - prideful.

“This what this is about? You comin’ down here given’ me forgiveness? Permission?”

"Oh shut up kitty-kat. Bigger stuff than you is going down, so park that attitude and listen good. My friend's gone missing. I want to *hire* you. You may hate her guts, but, dammit, I know you're good at your job. So, easy readies. I know you want to book it outta Freiburg so fast you'll leave the tarmac burnin'. This way we get what we both want. I find my friend, you get to keep on runnin'"

"I'm not running, Sparkles."

"Alright," I was surprised - she didn't double down on me. Which meant she really needed my help. Which meant it was serious. And god-damn it if that wasn't another icicle in the gut.

"So, what, Adora didn't show last night at the club? She turned up to her other gigs?"

"Like clockwork," I watched as Glimmer sat on the couch - my office is rather sparse. Cabinet for cases, worn out desk, and a couch to break bad news to sad families on. I hoped that wasn't the play by play here, like a sick echo of my day to day with faceless schmoes and their desperate stories: trapped in a fantasy world of hope, wishing the illusion would come real, before I had to take a pick-axe to that reality with truth and trauma.

"Any new associates? She been minglin' with any bad crews?" It felt like a pointless question. After all, Adora was where she was because she *wouldn't* accept any bad gigs. And I was where I was because I did. Because I thought that was how the world had to be. And I'd tried to get Adora to follow the programme.

I mentioned that big bad mistake, right? I knew I should've followed her, back then. Listened when she said "*Everything will be all right, as long as we're together,"* - of course I turned it right back around. We had a good gig.

After all, being cops meant we practically ruled the streets. Chief Hordak guaranteed protection rackets. We'd have been made up; a road to success. Of course, Adora had to go get a raging case of the *morals* . But then, if I thought about it, she always had been the girl scout. Honestly, looking back, past that veil of pride? If I cleaned the slime from my memories, she'd always backed me, always looked out, covered and done the *right* thing.

And I'd always done the right thing for me.

So when she'd handed her badge in after a few too many shifts where she couldn't shower herself clean, down to her soul, I'd cussed her out, called her a yellow-bellied crawler and told her to take a hike. She'd begged me to go with her, to strike it out as Private Agents, helping people. I laughed in her face - I wanted to be a made woman, be the important one for once. And without her, well, I could rise to the top.

I lasted a whole god-damn year before I had to bail. I won't bore you with the details - that'd take a book of its own and I don't do serials. Leave that to the radio.

I learned why Adora spent so long in the showers after a shift. When you stop and think, remember the look in people's eyes, remember the words, the pleading, it gets to you. Crawls under your skin and sets in. The city was and is rotten. And it made me rot.

Thank god for Scorpia helping me out of that gutter after I was practically hauled off the force. I got a beating, of course. You don't rat out your brothers in blue - course I didn't do that, but I was made an example of, for not following orders *precisely* . Scorpia picked me up from the Hospital - she'd been on the Force too, but left with me.

Ironic. I didn't leave with Adora, but when I saw the light, someone left with me. Is that irony? Who knows. Someone paid the bills at the hospital, though. Scorpia insists it wasn't her so I gots my suspicions. Starts with an A and smiles like an idiot But then again? Like I said, I'm proud.

Glimmer watched me across my office with a look that confirmed how dumb the question was. But hey, you gotta clear the air. I watched her deflate, the fight seeping away like water on dry sand.

"Honestly, no. But she's been distant. Sad, I think. I know Huntara's been leaning hard on her to move up on things."

Another name that made my jaw clench. Not many of those. Hordak, Sharon, my oh-so-doting mother, Adora (But for reasons

that hurt me more than anything. I think you get the picture. I might even get it done in colour) and Huntara.

She's one of those *talent* scouts from out west. All blunt attitude and cocky smiles. I think she's sweet on Adora. Maybe Adora's sweet on her.

Not like I care, of course.

"So, maybe she went out West?"

Glimmer shook her head, "Huntara was there last night. Looked shifty though."

"And how would you know what shifty looks like, Sparkles? Closest you've come to a crime is your dress choices."

"Y'know, that was almost funny. You are having a quiet time."

I ignored that and hauled open a desk drawer. A moment later I had a flimsy contract on the table, "$200 up front, $250 on completion, but I'll… waive it if the news ain't good. Anything you can tell me at all?"

“Um,” Glimmer fished about in her clutch and handed me a key, “Her… apartment key. I went round today but she ain’t there. I didn’t touch anythin’ either.”

“Called the cops?” another pointless question.

“Like that’d do any good. Adora and them, well… you know. And…”

“And they could be involved,” I provided. Honestly, seemed a bit small fry. Adora hadn’t known enough to be a bother. Worst thing she did was publish the odd article in the local penny rags that passed as newspapers. But who reads those?

Glimmer just nodded back at me, “I haven’t talked to many people. I.. I didn’t know who else might...care.”

Sometimes you get surprised too. That comment caught me like a whip, “I… uh…”

Of course, the soft smile on the other woman’s face also made me want to slap her silly, “Catra, I get it. You don’t have anger like yours unless… unless you care.”

“It’s *just* a job. I find Adora, it’s water under the bridge. And then maybe I can cut loose. Be free of… of the shadow. That’s all this is *Sparkles* .”

Glimmer nodded and stood, “Of course. I need to get back to *Salineas* . If you need me… you know where to call.”

She shot me a smirk and wink, then sashayed out. While I disliked the woman immensely, I couldn’t fault her figure. In another life, maybe we could’ve meshed. Another world we could’ve been friends. But too much history, too many sides taken. Adora and me, we had a bond. Broken and busted, beyond repair. And her friends, well, they were loyal.

As loyal as I should’ve been.

But maybe this was a chance to wipe that slate clean. Shake hands, part as whatever it was we were.

With a sigh I stood and hauled my blazer from the hook, then plucked my fedora. The rain was going to mess up my shirt, I knew it. My hair, I could care less about - I’d had it cut short to stop the bother. Some days I missed my wild mane. But it meant less chance of it getting yanked in a brawl, so I thought it a fair trade.

Right now I didn’t have much to go on - the panicked words of a best friend and some suspicions. But any good trail starts somewhere.

The streets were cold and wet, lit by the sulphurous glow of the streetlamps. Cars were few and far between, lonely chariots in this bleak excuse for a city.

Adora's place was in a quaint little part of town called *Brightmoon* . Pokey, full of whitewashed houses and towering apartment blocks. It was one of the few parts of town that still felt like a community. I mean, my office wasn't in a bad part of town - yeah I had to rent space above a mechanics, but Entrapta provided a good rate.

But my district was still dog-eat-dog. It was why I carried a snub-nosed revolver on the inside of my jacket and a blackjack up my sleeve.

Here, people smiled at you on the street. Not at this time of night, of course.

Adora's place was quiet - a squat apartment block done in pastel colours. The keys actually turned the lock first time round, which meant the place was well maintained. Empty corridors with thin but clean carpets. Gas lights though, showing it was a pretty old building.

I wasn't sure what to expect from her place itself. Adora had always been tidy, collected. A neat freak, Lonnie had said during our days at the academy. Just like Lonnie - brash, arrogant. Probably why she was hanging on in the force, with her two goons. How they haven't been gunned down yet, I had no idea.

But I was expecting neat. Not crazy.

And crazy was what I found. Well, partly crazy.

The apartment was a box - tiny kitchen and living space, bathroom (A luxury in this city - normally you shared with the floor) and an excuse of a bedroom. The bedroom was neat, crispand well ordered. Nothing out of place.

The kitchen wasn't bad either - everything away, aside from a plate of half eaten toast.

But the living area was suspicious - a large rug hanging from a wall. A tapestry? It seemed so out of place. Curious, I pulled it back and found the crazy: papers everywhere pinned to a corkboard on the wall covered in string. And a word at the centre: "Prime".

"What the hell have you been sniffing around in, Adora?"

I noticed a few grainy pictures tacked to the board and they made my blood run cold - Hordak.

Glimmer hadn't mentioned this - did she know? She must have known if she'd come round. But then again she'd probably just

ignored the wall hanging. I checked the papers - clippings about property developments, buy outs, missing people. The names were familiar.

People *I'd* helped track down. Or their bodies at least.

And then I saw my name circled with a string connecting me to the word in the middle. Prime…

I knew the name - Prime Real Estate. Some thought they were the wave of the future; gentrifying the city. I was pretty sure it was a mob front - but then again, whatw asn't in this drowned city of sin? All that on one side of the field, what did this mean? Was Adora… investigating? Why? And did she think I was involved?

Lights caught my eye out the window and I peered out. A patrol car had pulled up outside.

Glimmer hadn't ratted to the cops. Which meant they were here for some other reason. Coincidence?

I don't believe in them.

I had to think fast. So I tore down the corkboard and booked it out of the apartment, towards the fire escape. I made it, just as the rattling elevator creaked to a stop on Adora's floor and,

through the crack in the fire escape door, I saw a pair of familiar faces stalk towards Adora's place.

Grizzlor and Octavia. Hordak's chief flunkies from the department.

I made it back to my office somehow without incident, sticking to back alleys and side roads. Just to be safe, I kept an eye out for any more of my former-friends in blue, but the place was clear, so I hauled myself inside.

With the board stowed in my landlord's garage (She was very curious why I wanted to hide it, but she was more interested in engines than paper) I decided to follow up with Glimmer and the rest of *Salineas.*

It was only a short stop on the metro tram, rattling through the dingy night. *Salineas* was a jazz bar near the docks - kinda up-market considering, but it did good business. Bordering the middle class and the working stooges, it was a melting pot of drunks and debonairs - smooth enough to hang out at for the kids, but with enough grit you could swing a decent punch and not get barred.

I knew *that* from experience.

Owned by Misty Mer, *Mermista* to her friends and *That crazy broad* to me. To sum up, our five minute liaison ended when she turned a hose on me when she found out *I* was *the* Catra from Adora's past. Apparently she had loyalty, who knew.

Not my proudest moment, trying to get fresh with a bargirl, I know. In front of a friend I'd let down, no less.

But then again, Adora started it. I'd gone there to unwind after a bad day and Adora had strutted on stage in a red dress that showed her legs went all the way up and made her shoulders look like carved alabaster. A goddess. My goddess. I wished.

And then she'd started to sing. Now, I know I can sing - I purr like a cat, my voice has a rasp that, I'm not ashamed to say, carries kinda well. Brings a blush. Hey, if you have tools, know how to use 'em. I've gotten tips from people by using the right laugh, y'know.

But Adora… she's a riddle wrapped in something else. She was always so stiff at the academy, slightly awkward when speaking. But sometimes, put her on a stage, let the chips fall and she transforms. She becomes something else. She stands straighter, tilts her chin just so. And her voice just shifts, oiled to perfection. It reaches down into you, and *pulls* . It makes you feel things.

And no one has the right to have eyes like hers. Grey blue, like stormy skies. Mine are a mismatched blue and yellow. Yeah, two different colours. Adora used to call them her guiding stars. I always thought she was joking.

But when she saw me across that bar and sang *right at me* ?

The words that cut me to the quick?

" We feel the evil coming

And shadows all around

Danger surrounds us, but won't bring us down"

It chilled me. I couldn't look away as she'd sung *at* me.

Then the words hit again:

"Together we'll be heroes

Joining forces as one

Strong as the steel we carry

We rise like the sun"

It felt like she'd been mocking me. So I did the sensible thing - I'd gotten up, gone to the bar and hit on the pretty girl there and then pulled her over for a kiss.

It deteriorated from there. The other barman on duty accidentally set fire to a cocktail. Glimmer, one of Adora's backing singers (like I said - she is slumming) had bolted off the stage right *at* me. And

then Misty had hauled me out, clearly to continue but then *realised…*

And now, here I was, back outside. I'd snuck back a few times, bribed my way in. To watch. To listen.

Even though it broke my heart.

The least I could do. Literally.

Life has a way of cutting through the crap it seems.

I walked in as if I owned the place this time. I needed answers. I knew Adora was in over her head on something. Why though, that was the puzzle.

"Oh no, you know you aren't welcome here. Don't make me actually have to *do* something."

"Energetic as ever, Misty. Where's Sparkles?"

Misty was sat on the bar top while her maybe-steady-boy bustled behind the bar. Misty looked as stunning as ever - caramel skin and a waistcoat the colour of sea-foam. She tended towards suits but was every inch the woman. I respected that.

Mainly because she pulled it off so damn well.

"Not here," drawled the woman, disinterestedly.

"Gotta do better than that. She hired me."

"Oh?"

"Adora."

That got a tetchy sneer, "Of course. She bailed."

"She's in trouble."

"You askin; or you know?"

I just shrugged at that. But it was the bar-man behind her who answered with a beckoning hand. Misty ignored me as I sauntered past, but she shot me a look that was part frustration and part something else.

Hey, I know I'm a looker. Her loss. Maybe. Or maybe she was lucky. I know I'm bad news wrapped up in a disaster.

The barman led me to a booth and slid in opposite, "Better here. You don't want to just walk in and *announce* that."

He looked nervous. Which was weird. I knew the guy. Sebastian? Samuel? Cirrano? Something S with a last name like a bird. You'd have thought I'd be better with names and I am - when it comes to *cases* . If it's important, I remember it. He wasn't important.

"Well, cat among the pigeons. Gotta start somewhere. Adora was a no show then, you got theories?"

"You aren't the first to come asking about her."

"Do tell," I lounged back in the booth but I could feel my whole body tense - others having an eye out for Adora wasn't a good sign. She was alone against the scum of the city. Scum I waded through every day. I could hack it. Adora? She balked as soon as the reality of it hit.

"Yeah, asking about those missing people? Well… Adora's been asking questions. And, y'know, it's not exactly all fun on the high seas right now."

He paused as Misty strolled over and hip-checked him deeper into the booth, before she slid her shapely form in next to him, "Alright, room is *definitely* clear. No one we *don't* know hanging about. For whatever it's worth."

Her delivery could be described as bored if you were feeling charitable. But it was a facade - made clear when she fixed me with a glare that put Glimmer's earlier attempt to shame. I tried to return it with a scowl, but I think it wasn't even close to a draw. So I went with attitude.

"Something on my face, doll?"

"I'm not your doll, copper-top."

"Hey, I'm not blue no more."

Misty shrugged, "You got that stain right into your soul. Don't need Scorpia's steady-girls product to see you've got baaad written all down to the core."

I glared at that, "And how are you and Scorpia so close? Don't see her here."

"We aren't. I don't begrudge her keeping bad company though. We all make mistakes."

“Awww, still bitter?”

Misty huffed and leaned back, “I wasn’t the one looking to hurt someone that night.”

That hit like a slap on a cold morning in December. I worked my jaw but was saved by Cirrano or Sebastian or…. Hawk! Knew it was a bird.

“Ladies, I think we have more pressing issues. Now is the time for heroics and decisive ACTION! Not… spats.”

It was weird being chided by a busboy, but it felt like a night of firsts. So I just shrugged and ploughed on.

“Adora’s gone on the lam? I think she’s in deep. Saw some of Hordak’s heavy squad at her place before I cleared out. And I think it’s something to do with Prime. Name ring a bell?”

That got another sour look from the bored woman, “Yeah. We’re usually the life and soul of the party, but Prime’s been putting the screws on, trying to get us to sell up.”

“Really?”

"Ain't gonna happen. I have pull with the planning office. No way they can force it through. But Adora was asking a *lot* of questions."

I nodded, "So… no leads? Huntara not about?"

"She was last night but bailed early. Antsy as anything, like she was late for something."

Another suspect person. Cops and talents scouts and bears - oh my!

So it sounded like Prime was after Adora, but why? Connected to the missing folks? How? Yeah, I knew they'd been ditched in suspect ways. Nothing solid but locations and the manner of disappearance was always wrong. Failed carjackings, a mugging gone wrong, a body on a walk in the park in the bushes where they'd fallen badly.

Yeah, shady as anything, I know. But the cops weren't interested and… well.

Hordak's face was on the board as well, wasn't it?

Prime and Hordak, connected. Police not investigating suspect deaths, leaving it to little old me to retrace steps for hopeful families. But how did that tie to Prime?

I had another house call to make and the night was still young. I gave Misty and Hawk a nod, "Thanks for the spiel. You see Glimmer, you tell her I'm on the trail. She hears anything, leave me a note here, got that? And you see Huntara, make a note of that. See if you can't find out where she's at?"

"She rents at the Crimson, last I heard," offered Hawk, which got him a raised eyebrow from Misty. He shrugged and flashed a grin that was more a wince, "She was talking to one of the dancers, mentioned it to her in case the girl wanted a fun evening?"

"Uh huh," drawled Misty, before she rolled her eyes. She looked at me and frowned, "Still here, Kitty? Buzz off."

"And nice to see you too, Mer. Maybe take the stick outta your ass, it'll help you sit down better."

I flipped her off as I left, because frankly I hadn't the patience for anything more.

So, the Crimson was an option. I made it my next stop - it was halfway between there and my next stop, after all. And it's not hard to miss - one of those "No-tell motel" places, where marriages and dreams come to die. Drifters, runaways and spouses looking for a break from the routine, often not with their *other* spouse. Tale as old as time.

My first sign that something was off was the open door to one of the downstairs rooms - the place had an open plan, with a desk in a small shack acting as the reception. It was empty, with no sign of the night-host. The hairs on the back of my neck stood straight up and I loosened the gun in my jacket.

The kiosk wasn't empty - the host was lying on the floor, unconscious. He had a goose egg on the back of his head that was going to sting like hell in the morning, but he was breathing.

Carefully, I made my way to the open motel door and peered around the corner. The room was a mess - a suitcase was on the floor, upturned, clothes strewn everywhere. A chair was smashed all over the floor and the bed was upturned. A cold pit settled in my stomach as I saw the booted foot behind it and I feared the worst. But it twitched.

I inched around the detritus and found Huntara sprawled against the wall. She looked like she'd gone several rounds with the state heavyweight champ and come off worse. Considering she could have held the title herself (And may have done at some point) that didn't bode well. She fixed me with a bleary eye and glared.

"Come to… finish the job, pig?"

"I ain't no flat-top. Not any more," I muttered, then holstered my pistol, "Boys in blue do you over?"

“Sayin’... nothing.”

“Why’d they do it then, whoever they were?”

“Same as I told them… I don’t know anythin’...”

“They gunning for Adora? She’s vanished,” I offered. That made Huntara shift and sigh. She wheezed for a moment and seemed to relax. Hard to tell under the bruises and muscle though.

“...yeah. Thought I was sweet on her. That I’d know where she’d be.”

“You saying you aren’t?” I couldn’t help it, so help me.

That got a pained chuckle from the woman, “You kidding, she’s a dream. A firebrand. Who wouldn’t be sweet? But no, I know when a girl has a destiny, a dream of her own. That girl… nah. Didn’t stop me trying of course. But..”

“Know where she is? I need to… help.”

Huntara fixed me with a swollen eye, “I know you, don’t I? Seen you at Salineas. You that girl who caused that ruckus.”

“Guilty.”

“Strange. So, no… though when we spoke she had been looking at jobs, when I was trying to… ugh… get her to leave this hell-pit of a town.”

“Shame you couldn’t convince her.”

“Sounds like you care,” I just shrugged, “Last… she told me… she had an offer from Prime. That was a month back though. Now, no idea. I heard things through some contacts, things were getting hot around here. I wanted to warn her but she was a no show for her set. And then… I got the visit.”

“And you won’t say who they were?”

“They left me breathin’ - don’t want to give them a reason to finish the job.”

I nodded to that. I was kind of surprised she hadn’t made the short walk off the pier with a new set of shoes, but then again make your body count too high and a police department has to at least make a show of things. Scare tactics work, after all.

I stood slowly and frowned at the room, “Getting out of town?”

“Yeah. No point expanding my agency here. Too… risky.”

“Need a doc?”

The woman winced and slowly inched to her feet. Yeah, she looked more tenderised than a steak on sunday dinner. But still she waved me off, “I’ve had worse.”

Made me wonder what kind of talent she was used to if this was a normal day of the week to her. So I just shrugged again, “I may need to hit you up… for more info. Here’s my card, if you remember anything of course.”

Huntara just pocketed the small rectangle and shrugged, “G’night.”

“Yeah. You too.”

And with that I was back on those dark streets, no closer, stumbling around like a rat in a maze. Except Adora was working for Prime? An inside job? Was it an innocent gig and she’d found out something? Things looked grim - on the lam from her employers who wanted to keep her quiet? The mob sicking the cops on her as well?

My gut was clenched and I found it hard to breathe. I needed to know how close they were. And that meant calling in a favour.

I stumbled through the dim streets, suit soaked in the interminable drizzle. Ahead I could see the neon light of the diner. I checked my watch and grimaced - I could only hope they were taking an extra long break. And it seemed the angels were crying the good kind of tears tonight, because lo and behold, there was the squad car in the parking lot out front.

I pushed my way into the diner and flicked my arms, trying to dislodge *some* of the wet. At this time of night it was mostly empty, except for the three figures huddled at the back.

One of them glared daggers, the second eyed me curiously and the third looked like he'd wet himself. Hell, he probably already had.

"Looks like the cat dragged herself in." When Lonnie speaks, it's always a sneer. Wonder how that goes down at house calls - dealing with a grieving family, a beaten wife, a convenience store clerk. Real good *community service* . Protect and serve is a cause lost to the ages.

Lonnie adjusts her belt and leans against the counter, her gaze filled with contempt. No great shakes to me, is a look I've lived with since I was kicking cans in back alleys and disappointing dear old mom. So I just flip it right back at her. Tweedledum and tweedledee on either side of her look pretty uncomfortable. They aren't *bad* guys, just they follow where she leads. Lonnie treads a

fine line. She's not as on the make as some of the department. She's good for information, but it does mean I owe her favours too.

Doesn't make us friends. Of course she hates what I am, but then again I am useful. People don't like a badge, they don't mind someone like me as much. Maybe because they think they're better, so don't mind sharing. Know I can't do nothin'.

So they think.

I pull up into their little booth and smirk, "What, not deal going on doughnuts today. Kyle there's looking *peaky* . But you, Rog, you don't need no more padding."

The big guy just growls - not much of a talker Rog. Hell, he got through the academy by being a wall. His interrogation technique is exactly what the department prizes. I'll let you guess.Kyle? He turns sideways you lose sight of him. I've seen leaves put up more of a fight. But damn if he can't hit a fly on the wing. And he's booksmart. Occasionally the protectors of the city needs someone who can write without mouthin' the words out loud, I guess.

Lonnie looks impatient, "Whaddya want, Cat? You're paid up for now."

I study her. She's antsy, I realise. She doesn't want me here. So I push at that rotten tooth, looking for the sting, "What's eating

you, Lon? Seeing as you ain't eating. And that coffee looks stone cold."

"Bad night," is all she says. Kyle looks ill. Rog can't meet my eyes.

"Something bad? Nasty house call?"

"Yeah," Lonnie's grip on her mug tightens. Her gaze flicks to mine, eyes hollow. That's the first time I've seen her look like that, "How'd you do it, Cat?"

The stare makes me uncomfortable. Takes a bit for that to happen - thought I'd be immune, cold to all of this, "Do what?"

"Forget."

The implication is there. Something bad went down and I can feel my gut tighten, "Where's Adora…"

I watch confusion flit across Lonnie's face, then horror, "What? No… wait, what? Adora… what?"

Relief trickles into me like butterflies, but stops when I see a guilty expression on Lonnie's face. It makes me lean forward. I keep my eyes trained on Lonnie but I know the two other Stooges are

eyeballing me, “I’ve been round the houses tonight. Adora’s booked it, don’t know why, don’t know where. But something’s going on, maybe you heard something?”

It’s kind of impressive how Lonnie masks up - her whole face going marble and flushed, her dark skin a shadow of guilt hiding the truth. Kyle on the other hand is an open book with the passage underlined, so I turn the screws on him while Lonnie tries with a “Nothing you…”

“Hey kid, you remember Adora, right? Stuck up for you at the academy. I was a hard ass, a real bozo. Not the nicest girl in the world, but hey, you had the muscle here and the broad with the face that could sink a thousand ships. But Adora, she was good people. You guys didn’t do nothin’ to her, didja?”

I leaned back and pulled my blazer apart to show the gun strap. Rog growled again but it wasn’t a threat - more his sorta *Hey we don’t want to start nothin’* noise. Real versatile, that Rog.

“You threatening us, Cat?” came Lonnie’s drawl.

“I am, if you idiots laid a finger on Adora,” I’m not a big girl. Wiry I guess is the word you could use. But damn if I ain’t fast as a whip. Never got beaten in the boxing circuit at the academy. Mainly because I didn’t box - I just slapped the seven bells outta people while they windmilled. Except Adora. That girl boxed me in good.

Lonnie looks ready to pull her own sidearm, awkward as it'd be in a booth. Could I take three cops and the consequences? I didn't like my odds, but hey, it might take some of the stain off the city. Even if these were the closest to *good* cops you could find. But Adora… anyone who hurt her went beyond the pale.

"Lonnie, stop," I was surprised. Kyles voice was a warbling waver. And yet it froze Lonnie like a bucket of ice. I watch her as she looks down at the table top, while Kyle leans forward himself. The look he gives me is one I've never seen on him: it's concern.

"You got something to say, kid?"

"Yeah. Tonight we… we had to make a house call. Bad business. SOme gang from outta town, the Tungs. Strung a guy up. And made the family watch. I mean, the city's bad but… some things you don't do, y'know?"

I knew. Family was one of those unspoken rules. You crossed that line, it escalated things. This sounded bad, "Sorry you had to see that, kid."

"Yeah… we were supposed to uh.. To uh check up on him. Protection."

"Doing a damn fine job, officer," sometimes you can't help the sarcasm. I don't even bother trying to hold it back these days.

“Yeah, well… it’s got people spooked. All week. People been going missing. People *you* found, Catra, afterwards. Might not be good to be seen with you. You nearly being a snitch and all. WHo you been snitching to?”

“Those people I was asked to find. Not my fault you guys didn’t bother even checking *bushes* in the park.”

“Yeah, well… you looking for Adora? She going to turn up dead when you find her?”

That set my teeth on edge, “Say that again, pig.”

“Hey, you don’t get to call us that, kitty cat. You’re just pork too, gone off.” Lonnie’s sneer is back full force, but Kyle pulls her back into her chair. She looks shocked. Hell, I’m shocked.

“Can it, the both of you,” he looks straight at me, “Hordak’s antsy. People going missing. Some of it’s the Tungs. Some of it’s… well, I bet you can guess.”

“Protect and serve, huh?”

Kyle has the decency to look a little sick at that. Having a conscience won’t let you last with a badge.

“There’s an APB out for Adora. To bring her in, full custody. Protective.”

That’s interesting. If Hordak wanted her dead, well, it’s easier to show a body on the streets, not in custody. Even the laziest rag-typer would sniff about at that; maybe cause a bit of discomfort. Especially a young, blonde singer.

“Why?”

Lonnie shrugs, “Came direct from Hordak.”

“You guys pay a visit to Huntara? Know her?”

That got a lip twitch from Rog and a shudder from Kyle. Lonnie just shakes her head, “Nah, that was Octavia and Grizzlor. You *didn’t* hear that from me. Not that you can prove anything.”

“Why would I want to. I saw her. They tracking Adora, I guess?”

“Maybe. But here’s something you might want to think on - Huntara’s with the Tungs.”

That’s a surprise, “Then why’s she breathing?”

“A message, I guess? Others aren’t… we… we saw a few hanging about. Uh, we uh…” Lonnie looks ill, “Called it in and…”

Kyle, when he spoke, is dull and quiet, “Car fire a couple of hours later. FOund them outside of the city limits. That was… an hour ago. Been a long shift.”

If I’d been drunk, I’d have sobered up straight off. This wasn’t some spat. This was going to turn into a full blown gang war. Or could do, “You think the Tungs are after Adora too?”

“Maybe.”

“Huntara couldn’t find her… said she wanted to warn her.”

“Might be why she’s still breathing,” offers Kyle. His eyes are fixed on the middle distance - the stare of a man who’s seen too much in one day. Saw people come back from the war out West with that expression. Never quite there any more.

“Oh?” I led with.

“Maybe gave Octavia enough, told her she wanted out? Or maybe to send a message back ot her bosses. Though I doubt they like

people coming back as failures.”

That made me twist and spin in the wind. This was going to get ugly. And Adora was in the middle somehow, “Know anything about Prime?”

“The real estate company?” asks Lonnie. She looked suspicious again, “Uh… we do protection work for them. That’s it. Why?”

“Just another jigsaw piece. Any idea where Adora was last? You guys have to know something if there’s an APB, even a lead.”

“Briefing just said the docks. Guess people are keepin’ an eye on her *associates* ,” and Lonnie delivers that with a cold stare right at me.

“Huh, well. Been a *pleasure* catchin’ up, Lon. Kyle. Rog,” I did them the favour of tossing a twenty on the table. Dinner and a drink, the polite option. They hadn’t given me much, but they had fleshed out the painting a bit. Time to do some old fashioned research.

Trudging back through rain slick streets gives me time to think, to run it all over.

Gangs in the city, Hordak’s position being challenged and Adora in the middle, with Prime making moves to buy out land. The gangs

I could see, the company I could see - nothing drives down property like a good shooting. How was Adora involved? Had she found something in her job - evidence of a link? If so, why wasn't Hordak putting the screws on and burying her in a ditch.

Or maybe he had and this was all for show?

That made my hackles rise and bile settle in my gut. Because if Adora was gone, well, that meant life would be a bit greyer. A bit emptier.

Who was I kidding? It would be like a limb had been sawn off.

Something was nagging at me though. Something Lonnie had said. The missing people. People I'd been finding or looking for. It froze me in my tracks just before the corner to my office. I'm pretty good at big picture, if I do say so myself. And Lonnie can be subtle when she wants to be. She'd said they were keeping an eye on Adora's associates. And that I was known to have found people who had died.

Except the boys in blue hadn't been doing *most* of the killing it seemed.

But I knew where the bodies were buried. I was a problem. Maybe. Not just an inconvenience, no. Lonnie thought *I'd* had something to do with Adora being gone, even with my anger.

Which meant maybe they thought I had something to do with the *others* .

It wouldn't be the first time a private detective had staged a few cases to bring in business. Burglaries were easier to pull off. Murders, well… that was sick. But I knew of at least one sicko in another town who did that. Even dressed up as victims to fake pictures and things. The Double, they called them. Never caught the asshole either. Or they weren't sure, other than they skipped down and maybe headed south of the border.

And, well, I was a washout, a traitor in the eyes of the blue. Not a great leap to think that maybe I'd be taking a few hits from *other* players in the city after being ditched by my loyal former employers.

To survive the streets you do get a sixth sense which was why I now knew I had to be cautious. I should be prudent in my approach to my office. The suspicion was warranted, as I saw the patrol car just in the shadows next to my building. As I watch, Octavia barges out of Entrapta's shop, clearly riled. Entrapta follows and I breathe a sigh of relief - not roughing randoms to find me, at least. I can tell, however, that the engineer's babble is clearly in full flow. Must be what put Octavia off. I watch the car pull away and lurk further into the shadows as it drifts away down another street.

I'm no fool though and I stay put. Sure enough, it doubles back, at a slow crawl and I watch as Octavia jumps out, before Grizzlor pulls away, light flashing to make an obvious show. Octavia isn't in uniform now, which is a bad sign.

I could probably take her. Hell, she can't see right anymore *because* of me. Just an accident at the academy. But she had it coming.

But as someone said, discretion is the better part of valour. I think.

So I elect to sneak in through the back. Takes a while to circle around to the dirty yard that backs onto Entrapta's lot, but I manage it. And I get in through into her shop quietly - my office has an outside stair so no chance of getting there without Octavia spotting me.

"CATRA! I had some visitors. Are you in trouble? Do I need to put an ad out? I don't want to put an add out, it's a hassle. If you're in trouble can we make it go away, you're a good tennant."

Entrapta is not one to be quiet or to let a thought go unsaid. She also doesn't seem to sleep and is aware of everything. So I'm hardly surprised she ambushes me as soon as I'm in through the back door. Her overalls are one part cloth and fifty parts grease at this point and her goggles make her eyes look far larger than they are. It's unnerving to be stared down. Reminds me of that old lady at the corner shop with her random advice.

"Just some bad leads on a case, Entrapta. Nothin' to sweat about. Appreciate it if you could uh, cover for me."

“Oh don’t worry about that. They were kind of rude really. Didn’t want to buy anything! And I mean, really, who doesn’t find cathode ray tube FASCINATING!”

I eye the woman. Her face is the picture of innocence. Her smile is open and friendly. But then she winks and I’m reminded that this woman runs a successful business in a seedy part of time and *never* has issues with the local hoodlums. My first week in the office upstairs I had heard a ruckus but when I thundered down to help - I have my moments - I just found a wide eyed miscreant covered in oil and a smiling Entrapta with a blow torch.

After that I learned to not underestimate the woman. And I’m grateful she seems to like me.

“So what did they want?”

“Wanted to know if you’d been around today. Said you had, that you probably went home. Hadn’t seen you for a few hours. They wanted to look upstairs I said no, didn’t want you suing me for trespass, talked about the gas leak, fire hazards, how I might have to evict, all the rats, oh and that new import tube we had in and how well it works with our OTHER import…”

“Ok ok! Picture painted, ‘Trapta.”

“She’s still out there by the way.”

“Yeah I spotted her… how’d you know?”

“Please. Amount of times this place has been cased! So, what do YOU need?”

“I need to get that board… and then get some sleep before I hit the books.”

“Ohhh! The town archives?”

I nod at her. Good place to dig up dirt. The city is corrupt but they’re great for keeping records. The irony is that all the dirty laundry is there - it’s just a mess of legal paperwork and news stories. You just have to have the patience to root through it. Of course, once you find the dirt, the challenge becomes finding someone to do something with it. When the judges are bought, the lawyers too afraid to take a case and the cops are likely to string you up as help you, justice is a dirty word.

“Well, I hid it under some scraps. You need to get upstairs?”

“Can’t” I grumble, “Outdoor stairs.”

Entrapta gives me a look that is bemusement personified. Then she wanders across her workshop and yanks down a ladder from the ceiling.

“Maintenance hatch. For the wiring. Leads to a floor hatch in your outer office.”

Maybe those angels aren’t so bad after all.

A few minutes later and I’m crawling on my belly across my own office. Luckily I’ve always been able to see quite well in the dark. I don’t need much from the office - just to see if it’s been gone through. Just because the cops are following the rules, doesn’t mean there aren’t others on the case.

Luckily the place is clear, no signs of disturbance.

Once I was happy my office hadn’t been defiled and ransacked, I snatched my little book of contacts and crawled back out to the vent. Entrapta kindly informed me that Octavia was still out on the street. Except it looked like she was being bugged by some of the street kids. That suits me just fine.

Instead I turn my attention to the board - and it’s a lot more in depth than I’d realised at her place. All the names, some small notes on where they worked and even links to who they knew. And that was interesting - seems they were all acquaintances. Quite how I wasn’t sure. I glance at the mysterious note, then back at the board.

Real estate, Hordak and his little racket being challenged. Adora working for Prime. Sounded like Hordak was expanding his influence, getting rid of the competition, except someone started getting rid of *his* goons and that led to the Tungs thinking they could step on in, maybe? And Adora perhaps had the key to it all. And me? Maybe I was a handy catspaw, a scapegoat to pin these deaths on. Or maybe they thought I knew more than I was letting on.

The problem with a busy mind is you can come up with all sorts of bad ideas, especially when you're exhausted and waiting for a knock on the door. Entrapta was a lifesaver though and set me up in her pokey little backroom. I knew I couldn't head to my apartment - they'd be casing the joint as well and frankly I didn't feel comfortable sleeping there if some people with disagreeable attitudes might decide knocking was a courtesy too far.

Sleep was slow coming but when it hit it was like the sleep of the dead. I don't dream often and when I do they aren't worth remembering, not for my sanity.

In that dark void I do *think* . I don't call it dreaming. No chorus girls or show-dancers in my visions, no bad memories of my mom's burned face as she growled her hate through cigarette stained teeth and wine soaked lips. No, that's for the bad nights, where I know the space in my bed is lacking in warmth. Opportunities missed, not grasped. A hand not taken.

Introspection - I hate it. Like I said, pride.

My thoughts fli, birds on the wing, through asky of possibilities. Buildings with foundations of blood, gunfire and dead cops, a woman in a red dress and ice blue eyes walking among them, a strange smile on her face.

Death becomes her.

The sun's barely over the horizon, casting Entrapta's workshop in a dim glow when I wake up. The couch she keeps in the place is ratty and smells of motor oil. I think it's an extra shelf to her. Either way, a bed is a bed. And the rest helped settled my addled mind and gave me a worrying thought.

What if Adora wasn't running. What if she'd picked a side?

That didn't sit well. Adora was a goof, but a noble one. I couldn't see anything pushing her into that life, not after she made such a ruckus about the police. Adora cared about the *big* things. Nothing, *nothing* would change that. Little things didn't matter to her. That was something I realised.

Yeah, the heart makes you a sucker, I know. I'm the biggest schmuck out there.

Entrapta must've been up all night as she was snoring at one of her benches. I nudged her awake to let her know I was bailing. I didn't fancy my chances calling at my place for a change - too risky. So I just elect to haul on a spare overall set over my suit

and slip out the back. An empty tool box and a spare set of goggles from Entrapta and wham-bam I'm yet another blue-collar-joanne.

I don't give credit easy - they clearly had the place staked out all night. I can spot Grizzlor not being subtle behind a newspaper, plus some easy to make out plain-clothes rookies loitering near a busted car. Probably hauled out of impound as a deniable vehicle. A step up from parking a patrol car, but still - those boys don't know how to be casual. Still got the stick rammed up their asses from the Academy, clearly. I even tip them a nod and carry on. I came from an alleyway the other side of the block, so they barely pay me a mind. Grizzlor doesn't even look my way.

Three blocks out I hop a tram. The crush of the crowd keeps me masked from another patrol and I can see they're looking antsy. Things must've gotten worse overnight.

Not my problem yet. Yet.

City Hall is my destination. And even at this time of day, when honest folk work to death and the powerful lounge with their second espresso it's bustling. The gears of power turn, no matter how rusty the cogs, I guess.

No one cares about the records department, even less so someone in a dirty set of coveralls. Of course, I ditch those once I'm inside and hide it in a janitor's closet. If I'm being tailed, you gotta change things up. So I sneak into an unoccupied office and snag a discarded jacket and tie, leaving my own in repayment.

Yeah, I clash, but the suit's getting old anyway. I was hoping this job might get me new threads anyway.

The records department is a grand name for a cramped cellar. Rows of metal shelves and dusty card-boxes. They barely staff it and today is my lucky day - no one's on duty. Hell, they don't even lock the door. Or they don't lock it well. Some jimmying with a trusty switchblade and we're coming up roses. Better that than pushing up daisies.

Inside I set to work. I have my list of names and the dates, along with articles to reference.

It's dull work. But don't let the fancy title fool you. Private Eye basically means a *lot* of reading and research. Hell, being a cop usually means that too, if you aren't just in it to make some extra readies on the side of course.

After a few hours I'm doing ok. Several of the names were active in blocking Prime purchases. Others were clearly Hordak's compadres - some society pictures of the ghoulish Police Chief glad handing a few of the missing men at some fancy do. All glitz and glam and thin glasses. The sort of drink that doesn't get you drunk but makes you wish you were.

Their deaths were neatly recorded, autopsies a matter of public record. Some pages were missing, some of the coroner's details clearly made more *friendly* . But if you read between the lines, some of these guys went in worse ways than others.

Whacked upside the head with a hammer.

Drowned.

Shot, point blank.

A fall.

Suicide . That one got a chuckle. Guy apparently shot himself in the head after he hung himself. Clever guy.

The amateurish stuff screamed *gang* . The subtle stuff screamed *cop* . Clever corrupt cops tread a line. You don't know how much of the slime your fellows will tolerate. So, best be discrete. Yeah, the blue line turns outward when their own are threatened… but then again they do *not* like people who can upturn the whole gravy boat.

So, some of these boys seemed to have fallen foul of Hordak. And some seemed to be targets for someone else.

Common factors? Prime and *me* . Because I tracked down the dirt, the trails that led me to them. At the time it was just acquaintances and following their haunts to find things out. The why I tended to avoid - that's a road to misery sometimes. And,

like this, you knock the hornets nest and get stung. Anyway, it was all cut and dried and I handed over to the *authorities* . Nice, neat, families paid up, I got drunk to make the crying stop.

Thing was, some of this stuff - their connections to Prime? That wasn't exactly *obvious* . And no way in hell a gang would just know that stuff. Hell, I struggled to sift through this stuff. And unless you were *looking* for the connections, well, that was like spotting a needle in a haystack at a glance. Yeah, incidental, but half this stuff was buried in memos and meetings. Verbal conversations recorded.

Hordak would have known *some* of it, maybe, if he kept tabs. But this was a lot for someone to keep track of, especially with his whole *other* job. And while I knew Hordak was a control freak, this seemed to be too much for just him. How'd I know that? Well, hardly anyone was in his inner circle. The department was corrupt - he encouraged it because then no one tried looking at *him* . But he didn't trust anyone with *his* stuff. All personal, all quiet. Yeah, Grizzlor and octavia were his primo flunkies, but I doubted even they got a look in. That baby-faced assistant of his helped, I'm sure, but the guy was mute. Never liked the guy.

But Hordak was *busy* . He barely cared about day to day policing. But still, he had enough going on and I couldn't see him digging through all of this - making these connections. He managed big stuff, delegated broader deals and protection rackets and punished things that went wrong but, like I said, this was involved to a degree that was surprising.

These killings looked targeted. The end result was a drop in prices - good business for Prime. Also, most of these guys were grade-a

scumbags. But *some* of them were clearly *with* Hordak. And yes, their deaths meant more access for Prime, but likely they hampered Hordak a lot: these guys were Guildsmen in some of the city minor committees, or men of influence. Yeah, some were low-grade workers, but they were Union boys.

Adora's clever. Had she spotted the pattern? Had Prime wanted her gone? Maybe Hordak was after her *for* Prime, to see what she knew, to see if she had things squirreled away. No point icing her if she had dead drops for people to find. That game of hunt-the-mole was a pain.

That might be why the department was in the dark. Minimise the leak. Just grab her and let Hordak sort out the mess?

A door creaking open sent me to my feet. In a flash I was squeezed between the stacks, black-jack in hand. I could hear the click of heels on the floor. Then the sound of a pistol being cocked. Ice filled my veins.

A soft hum came from near my desk and I try to peer around the corner, but a stack of file boxes obscures my view. Then I hear the sound of something landing on the desk and the heels click away. The door creaks shut with a faint clunk and I exhale.

Cautiously I make my way back to the desk.

There's a new file there. It's all about Prime's purchases and a list of *new* names.

More targets? Or more leads to follow?

At the back of the file there's a card - a note.

Warehouse 16. Midnight. Come alone.

It's written in a neat script, not one I recognise. For a moment I wondered if the mystery visitor had been Adora. But if she knew I was here, wouldn't she have called out?

Or did she hate me that much? Well, obviously not enough, if she was giving me this. Or was it even meant for me? Or just being deposited back in a stack, to be lost in the filing all over again?

Answers would be forthcoming at the warehouse. It stank of a setup, but hey - like I said, I never met a bad idea I didn't like.

The names were interesting - more Union guys, a few Lieutenants on the force. But these guys seemed to be relatively *new* to things. No real records of activity. Replacements perhaps? One was of very *very* clear interest:

Angella Moon. Counsellor. Entrepreneur.

And *no* clear connections to Prime at all. That was weird. Well, not directly - she obviously moved with the others on the list, but she had no investments, no connections. No controlling stakes.

Were they targeting her? She could be obstructing Prime - that seemed reason enough.

Should I warn Glimmer? That seemed prudent.

The other files I swept away into boxes. But this one I kept as I left the department. I ducked into another office and stole a new hat, then made for the lobby, where I had to pull my hat down over my eyes as four patrolmen entered through the front doors. I had to swerve and headed for the stairs as two were blocking the exit, eyeing everyone who passed. Clearly I wasn't as evasive as I thought. Or someone had tipped them off? My mystery visitor?

On the mezzanine I manage to hide against a pillar and survey my options. Front doors - no go. Back doors are through the council offices which means a lot of witnesses. Second floor windows have a twenty foot drop. And I might be agile but even I can't run with shattered ankles. Mom taught me that at age six.

Cry me a river.

But fire escapes? That was an option. I make my way back through the upper floors to the rear of the building. Outside I can hear sirens - backup. Is it for me? Or did they hear that Adora was here and the stops are being pulled out.

Either way, something tells me this file would be better served *not* in Hordak's hands. Call it intuition. Or spite.

I find an office with access to the fire escape, but of course the window is barred shut. That problem is solved with hand application of the but of my revolver. Of course, it's noisy and garners me some unwanted attention from a mousy broad with big eyes and a heck of a set of lungs as she starts bawling *POLICE!*

Why? I was just leaving. So I wave my pistol at her in a vaguely intimidating way, which sends her scurrying.

I recall I mentioned me and bad ideas.

I shimmy down the escape as fast as I can, though I have to drop the six feet at the bottom into a pile of trash sacks. Alleyways are the same uptown as downtown. How the world works I guess.

Of course I should've expected that my trackers would have the back covered too.

“Freeze, rat.”

Grizzlor is a fat asshole. Someone I could outrun at the academy. Someone I could still outrun now. The .38 revolver in his hand? Yeah, never met a bullet I could outrun. Never had to, never want to find out. I think I’ll come off worse.

“Grizz. What a surprise. Hear you’re looking for me.”

“Yeah, turncoat. You been selling us out to the Tungs. Mind you, I’d be happy to do this without that reason.”

“Hey, wait up now! I have my hands up!”

Grizzlor’s smile is the wrong side of nasty. His red hair and blotchy face make him look like some sort of troll, the sneer doesn’t help, “That’s easy. Resisting arrest.”

I watch as he raises the pistol. My own is back in its holster. Don’t believe the serials - that quick draw crap doesn’t work. And I’m not a great shot over twenty feet.

Turns out I don’t need to be as a shot cracks from behind me. Grizzlor staggers, eyes wide in shock. I watch his gaze flick behind me, but my eyes are glued on the pistol still levelled at me. He stumbles and tries to raise it. But two more shots sound out and red blossoms like macabre flowers on his blue tunic. The revolver

tumbles from his nerveless fingers and clatters uselessly on the concrete.

That sound breaks me from the shock and I spin to find my saviour. All I see is a flash of a coat vanishing around a corner, obscured by steam from a vent. I spare a glance back at Grizzlor's corpse - I doubt any excuse I have will fly. Doesn't matter that my revolver is cold and in its holster - I'd make an easy patsy. Especially as it seems people have it in for me already.

Justice doesn't seem to have a consistent hit rate in Freiburg after all.

I sprint around the corner in time to see a taxi squealing out of the alleyway. I can't make out the occupants but I can hear boots on pavement behind me as someone finds Grizzlor's body. Time to split.

The tram does good trade for me - a mask for my journey, huddled on a bench. Honestly, I don't really know where to go. They'll be watching *everywhere* . Especially if I'm now down as a cop-killer.

The warehouse is my only option. Hordak's at the centre of this, Adora too. Maybe she called the hits? I can't help but chuckle at the thought. She'd rather die than work for Hordak, that I knew. Life as a singer in some seedy club, rather than making bank for turning a blind eye.

But it never stopped at just a blind eye. And to look at her as she sang, she definitely seemed to have the better deal.

After a few stops I hopped off in the swankier business district - not the first place the boys in blue would look for me. Not much imagination, those crusaders of *justice* . They'd lock down my bolt holes, my friends. Keep them under watch. I had some time. So I made a call. It was short.

"Sparkles?"

"Catra? Have you found her?"

"No. She's in deep. Don't have much time. Boys in blue are looking but don't think it's good. They're after me, think I killed a cop."

"Did you?"

"Whaddya think, Sparkles? Listen… I have a list of names. Similar to the list of people who died… Sparkles, you mom is on the list. I don't know what it means. If she's involved or… or if she's next."

The silence on the line was deafening. Then she spoke, " *I… I have to go."*

"Get out of town, Sparkles. Get far. I have a feeling things are gonna get hot. Take your squeeze and run. Get safe."

"But… Adora… and what about you?"

"Adora and I… well, it was bound to end like this, wasn't it? Some tragic end. That's how the breaks land, Sparkles. Story of the world. Good guys finish last, scum just a bit after. I'll find her. Get her out if I can."

"Catra…. Just… you're police scum. But… look after yourself. ANd if you find her, look after her. That's… that's all she ever wanted, I think."

Well damn, if that doesn't make me tighten up, "Sure. Sure. Now, get outta town. Fast train. I hear Thaymor's good this time of year."

All I get is the click of the line as my change runs out.

After navigating some more back-streets I hop another tram to another dingy part of town - tenements, broken dreams and graveyards of the lost. I'd grown up in a place just like it. A sour homecoming of sorts. Perfect place to hide - the cops never bothered with them. Why bother?

I have time to kill, so I find a building that looks like even the rats have given up on it and huddle down to read through my purloined file. It's got more than names - full listings of Prime's goals too. Seems it's a real drive to secure vast parts of the city. Mostly gang areas or poor tenements. The docks, too. Including the Warehouse I'm set to meet at.

Definitely a setup.

Watching the sun set and listening to the quiet sounds of the dead part of a city is a strange thing. It's meditative, I guess. Now I have been known to sleep in my office, mellowing in the burn of liquor and cheap cigarettes. The buzz of street lamps and the sound of cars as they rumble by - it's kinda hypnotic.

Out here where all you can hear is the distant cry of children at play, the yells of arguing spouses and the distant clank of trains? Isolating ain't the word. Detached, maybe?

Right now I'm adrift and not sure of the path back. If I hadn't taken this job would I be on the block? Probably: just I wouldn't have expected the bullet in the back. A blessing really, Adora vanishing. Gave me a head start.

I pluck the card from the file and stare at it. I know I have a choice. One path is to the railway, hop a car and head out West, find a new town, start fresh with the limited readies in my pocket and the gun in my mismatched jacket. It'll be hard, but not like I haven't had to crawl out of a pit before. Yeah, Adora could die.

But she could be dead already. I'd leave the past behind, start fresh. Cut the pain away, like a festering wound.

The other choice was to head to the heart of this, grasp the nettle and take a step into the lair of the beast. Because it could save Adora. It would give me answers. It would at least mean I wouldn't spend years looking over my shoulder.

I said I'm no hero. But once again I must raise my relationship with bad ideas. This time, both options seemed equally poor. But, really, when you strip away the pomp and circumstance, any story worth telling is about a dame. And the person who loves her.

So it wasn't even a choice.

Which is why I'm on the docks at midnight, outside a warehouse that has seen better days. The number on the side is peeling in the salt air. A metaphor for the city perhaps - flaking, falling apart, not fit for purpose as the waves batter and stink up all around. The air is full of brine and oil. Who knows, by the end of the night it might be the last thing I ever smell.

I was careful crossing the city. Not even a taxi - no point risking in case they'd managed to get some old pictures of me distributed to the cab firms - those guys are so in the pocket of the police I'm surprised Hordak doesn't issue *their* badges too. Which did get me wondering about that impromptu getaway by my mystery saviour.

I walk down across the weathered boards around the side of the warehouse. THere's a railing and a drop to the briny foam below. Fairly easy to get rid of a body from here. If this is as etup it'll be efficient. I feel kind of resigned to the whole thing. But I'm no idiot. Not entirely. I didn't bring the file, for one thing - stashed it under a floor board in that abandoned tenement.

Occasionally my ideas aren't terrible. Means I might have some leverage. Or a bluff.

The warehouse itself is dark - no lights inside that I can see. It's got a rolling metal door at one end, for trucks and boxes and a couple of side doors - one of which looks welded shut. The other one, however, has a busted padlock. Gingerly, I make my way inside.

The place is pretty much like I expected - moldering crates stacked high, shadows that make your imagination play too many tricks. Carefully I let the black-jack slide into my grip. No way to get a good shot off in here - and grappling with a gun in close quarters is a good way to end up doing emergency brain surgery on yourself. Seen it go bad too many times. Even if you get the other bozo, bullets *ricochet* .

The place seems deserted - there's dust everywhere, the only light coming through the skylights above. The dockyard floodlights casting moon-beam like lances of light into this dank waiting room of purgatory.

A sound makes me pause - the intake of a breath. I tighten my grip and try to pinpoint the sound - the crates make it hard.

Well, in for penny, in for a pound of flesh. I had been invited here.

“Hey? So…. I’m here. Alone.”

Heels click on concrete. I can make out a figure, immobile, in the dark, ahead of me. I move towards it.

But as I get closer I realise it’s just a jacket draped onto a crate. Not thrown. Draped. Purposefully.

A distraction.

The hit *hurts* . The blackness smothers me like my mothers cold embrace.

Waking up is, of course, worse. It’s made more uncomfortable to find out that I’m tied to a chair.

“I preferred the red suit. More your style.”

I exhale through my nose. Of course. *Of course* .

"Hey, Adora."

I look up through bleary eyes as her heels click across the floor. She's stunning, as ever. A red dress this side of sinful, blonde hair done in a braid and a small clutch at her side. HEr eyes are cold, ice blue, but with a hint of something else in them.

"I'm sorry about this Catra. Had to go down this way. Only way to be sure."

"Sure of what? That no one will find out you dirty little scheme? That you've been working with Hordak all along? Or did you tie me up so we could have a heart to heart?"

That seems to hit a mark - Adora looks frustrated and she huffs. She plants her hands on her hips in a very unladylike manner. Not that I mind. It accentuates just the way I like it. I don't even try to hide my leer.

Funnily, she just smirks at my look.

"Glad I've still got it with you, Catra. No… this is necessary. You're in a bad place."

“That’s obvious, idiot. So, all this to just… get me?”

“Well, you were giving everyone the runaround,” Adora’s smirk is teasing. It feels weird. Mind you, all I feel right now is a deep unease. This girl who spent so much time decrying the evils of the corruption of this city and she’s involved in the worst of it?

“It’s a game to you? You serving me up on a platter, huh?”

Adora’s face takes on a sad tinge, “It’s the only way, Catra. I hope you can forgive me.”

“Kinda hard when I’ll be doing the long sleep soon, huh?”

The blonde looks like she’s about to speak, but clamps her mouth shut and just studies me. A moment later I hear a door creak open, followed by the sound of shoes on the floor. A figure rounds a stack of crates and my heart sinks.

Hordak stalks into the pool of light. Only now do I realise that someone has one of the overhead lights on. It’s not all that bright, but it still glints off the Police chief’s gold lining and the various commendations arrayed on his thin chest - meaningless tin, really. The man looks positively skeletal, eyes bloodshot from stress or drink. And his smirk is ugly.

Adora shoots the man a look that looks fearful, "You uh…. You sure you're alone? I…"

"Fret not, my dear. Octavia is outside but… she is none the wiser. She knows better. Better it be kept between us."

"Adora, he's gonna kill you too, you know that."

Hordak chuckles at that, "Cat *ra* . Perpetual disappointment. Why would I do that? She still serves a purpose. She is *cowed* . She knows her place. And, frankly, it'd waste time trying to train up a new lackey. You, on the other hand… you have been a problem. Finding where the bodies are buried, literally… or maybe *getting* them buried."

"Hordak, why would I do that?"

"Why does anyone do anything? Money? Prestige? Petty revenge. We all know how bitter you were. Why do you think Adora is helping me? She's *afraid* of you, Catra. Your paltry rise in the ranks was never enough for you. We knew you had *higher* aspirations. And then you decided you were too good for us."

He looms above me, hands behind his back. Adora, behind him, fidgets. I need to buy time - maybe Glimmer or *someone* is coming. That hope is dying by the moment. Sold out by the one woman I… I…

“I know you’ve been driving up crime, getting Prime to buy out real estate on the cheap. But it backfired, huh? The Tungs sniffing around ‘cos they think you can’t hold your turf down? Snag in your plans huh? Well, I got proof. Squirrelled away. Kill me, it goes to the DA, to the state bar. Even you can’t reach that far.”

Hordak’s face twitches and he snarls, “Oh we have time. Time to make sure you talk. I mean, you’ll probably be dead at the end. But I can weather a little controversy. I do like to make sure, though.

I look over at Adora who is staring at me impassively, “Adora… please… you can’t do this. Can’t help this *monster* …. Please wake up. Please…”

She cocks her head at me and holds her clasp in front of her, “Catra…”

“Adora…” I inhale and I feel a weird sense of peace settle. I glare at Hordak, “You… monster.”

“I am practical. So is Ms Greyskull. She saw the benefits of operating in my service. Everyone has their price.”

“Adora… how… how could you? I love… I loved you?”

The blonde has her eyes downcast and is rooting through her clasp. She pulls out a large pistol and my eyes widen as she levels it at me.

"You love me?"

I close my eyes and inhale shakily, "You… idiot."

The shot rings out and I tense. There's no pain. I expect pain. Or cold. Maybe a spreading warmth, or the coldness of the impending grave?

But there's none of that.

There's the clatter of something hitting the floor though.

Slowly, I open my eyes. Adora is standing there, gun held steady in her hand, barrel smoking. Her face has a hard expression on it. Fury and righteous fire in her eyes. Trained on something in front of me. My eyes track down to the body of Hordak, slumped to one side. He appears to have developed a terminal case of lead poisoning. Adora levels the pistol again and fires twice more. The body jerks and twitches, a marionette with its string slice, then goes still.

I look back up at Adora, who looks back at me with eyes now filled with something else: tears.

“I love you too.”

I’m dumbstruck. I feel like I’ve just gotten a peek at the corner of a page of a book the library just got in.

“Adora… what’s going on?”

“Baby, he wasn’t wrong. I have been working for him,” Adora smiles a devilish smile. It does things to me I shouldn’t probably feel, considering she just fired three shots into a man’s back. “But… I was doing it for a reason. He threatened you, once he found out about me working at Prime. I had been planning to get in with Hordak anyway. He just jumped my schedule up.”

“He...threatened me?”

“Knew I was sweet on you. Wanted to use Prime to make money. But hey…. That’s why we set it up. You catch flies with honey, set the mark up on the long con. But then he *threatened you* ,” her eyes are hard again, “He miscalculated.”

“So, what… this…?”

“Oh, baby. This wasn’t supposed to happen. This was… an opportunity though. And I hope you can forgive me. I really do.”

“Wh...what?” I’m honestly lost. Adora *is* in the thick of this? “An opportunity? Wait… I was *bait?”*

“We had Prime setup. Feeding Hordak names and deals. He was wrapping himself up in paranoia, cutting off his allies and making enemies. The Tungs…. We didn’t expect. We had hoped to get enough involvement that even Hordak couldn’t bribe his way out. Prime was supposed to go under and drag him down with it. Nice and legal. But then the gangs got pushy. People died who weren’t supposed to.”

“That’s what happens when you play with fire, doll. You get burned.”

Adora laughs at that, “You aren’t wrong Kitten,” again I *shouldn’t* be feeling this. I’m angry, confused, hurt and shocked. But Adora’s alive. And, apparently, my guardian angel. I’m still muddy on that one.

“So, what happened?”

“Hordak never goes anywhere without a guard. Or he’s in a social circle. But he shares *nothing* . Except with underlings he can dispose of. Closed circles, y’know?”

"Yeah. It's how he keeps control."

"Exactly. And then he connected you to the deaths and made one and one make three. He mentioned it when he was with Octavia after visiting my office."

"Wait you have an *office* ?"

"Focus, Catra. It's a front."

"You keep saying *we* . Please don't tell me Sparkles is involved. It'd explain how incompetent this is…."

Adora scoffs, "No."

"Oh goo-"

"Her mom is though." And if that doesn't make my eyes bulge. Prissy, goody two shoes Angella?

"What."

"We had wanted to take this all the way up. I just broke that plan though. But I have a good solution. Hordak never tells anyone anything. His empire dies with him. The plans and knowledge about Prime, too. Angella controls the people who *have* invested

in it. So, Freiburg gets a long term plan to gentrify, social programmes. Maybe it sticks, maybe it doesn't."

"This is… it's too big, Adora. It can't work. You just shot a man."

"Two men, actually."

Again I stare at her. She looks like an angel. An angel of death. A valkyrie. A demoness sent to yank me straight to hell.

"You're a criminal Adora."

That just gets me a shrug, "Careful with the accusations there, gumshoe. I think you hopped on that train long before me."

"I didn't *kill* people!"

"So I should've just let Hordak have you dragged into an alleyway, have your throat cut? Let Grizzlor have some time with you? No. I'd rather be damned a thousand times than let that happen."

"Adora I don't MATTER, I'm just a face in a sea of faces I'm…."

And then she's there, fisting my shirt and pulling me up hard. My wrists strain against the rope and damn if the girl can't tie a knot.

Again, that's something I'll have to file away for later. Those icy blue-grey eyes bore into me. Storm on the horizon. Her voice is a sibilant hiss, "You matter to *me* ."

And then she kisses me. And damn if it isn't like a gunshot - my heart stops and my skin is all heat and tension. If I died now it would be as a happy woman. The world could be crumbling around us, lightning flashing and consciousness slipping into a void and I'd be content.

She breaks it with a murmured "Wow."

I can't help but interject, "Don't ruin it, doll."

Her smile is shy now, tentative, "I… I understand if you hate me, Catra. This was a risk. But I needed to draw him out. And he wouldn't risk anyone else wanting to know. And now I have to do one more thing."

I baulk, "You aren't handing yourself in!"

Adora's smile turns into a grin, "Oh hell no. Now, you sit tight… don't go anywhere. Oh, and keep a hold of this…."

She slips a card into my pocket and squeezes my thigh. Then, with a winkl she slips into the shadows. I hear the side door bang open again and the sound of running feet. Octavia sprints into

view and skids to a halt. I watch her beady eyes take a view of Hordak's corpse, then my prime self, all trussed up and ripe for the slaughterhouse. Her smile is not pleasant as she reaches for her truncheon - clearly I'm not due a quick end.

Her smile falters as a pistol emerges from the shadows and presses against the back of her head. Watching her face go pale is like all my Christmasses come at once. I can't hear Adora, but I see Octavia nod jerkily as she carefully unhooks her holster and fishes her revolver out. Something happens I can't make out, but then the gun is back in and Adora seems to vanish. Octavia freezes for a moment longer, then spins around.

Clearly there's no one there as she turns back to me with a snarl and pulls the pistol out. It's Adora's. My eyes widen as Octavia levels it at me, clearly rattled and wanting to end this. But the gun just clicks - the cylinders empty.

Her surprise is compounded by the sudden shouts behind her - yells of "Freeze!" and "Drop the gun!"

Octavia turns and if it isn't the three stooges. I'm not sure whether to laugh or cry. Hell, I have something in common with those angels. I'm either as good as dead or about to undergo a change of fortune.

Seems those angels owe Adora a favour. Kyle sprints over to untie me while Rogelio cuffs Octavia. Lonnie eyes Hordak's body with distaste, then looks at me with a smirk, "Little birdie told us to be

here. I would ask why you did it but even I can't swing you being all tied up while someone else holds the murder weapon."

"That's… jumping the gun, ain't it Lon. You know something?"

"Oh I think I'm in *Prime* position to make comments, Catra. And, well, about time we had a change of things in the department. Guarantee this will shake the tree. Grizzlor, Octavia and the head Honcho down and out? Questions gonna be asked. People close by are gonna get burned. Us grunts, well… we're placed well."

"Well, good to have friends in soon-to-be high places," I manage as Kyle gets the ropes off, giving me a chance to rub my wrists.

"We need a statement."

"Do I need a lawyer?"

"Probably. Got a Mr Beuregard Archer waiting for you downtown."

"Convenient."

"Ain't it just?"

And like that, it ends. I worked it all out, but I was just a piece on a board, being played by people with more skin in the game. Admittedly, I was some of that skin. Processing and wrangling is pretty quick - My lawyer is Glimmer's squeeze. A perpetually preppy, happy guy with a voice that only cracks twice under the sudden strain of what he's *clearly* just learned. He even manages a laugh that is pitched a bit too high, but I can work with that.

Turns out, Adora was on the money - the department is in a panic. And my position means I am very much in the clear - hard to be accused of murder when an Officer know to be coining it in is holding the weapon. She tried blaming it on *someone* but had no idea who it was. And, frankly, I lay it on thick, how Hordak was trying to pin the whole body-finding debacle on me. How Octavia and Grizzlor had been tailing me and tried to shoot me. The Grizzlor bit I had to fluff, saying there was a shooter, but that it *could* have been Octavia. I never saw who it was and my own gun had a different calibre round to the ones Grizzlor died from.

Rounds that matched the ones that killed Hordak. That matched the gun Octavia had.

I could see the way this was going. The DA was going to paint a picture of an ambitious cop, clearly wanting a bigger piece of the pie. The Prime issue was ignored as, lo and behold, it collapsed and other consortiums swooped in to snatch the land.

Consortiums owned in part by the Moons.

It took a few hours - I gave over my whole list of findings, including the list of names Adora had donated - it clearly implied further targets for Hordak and, by extension, Octavia. I was clearly some poor patsy.

Bow, as I end up just calling him, shakes my hand on the steps of the police station and said he believed I would be called to testify, maybe to corroborate my findings too. I was a kidnap victim after all.

I turn to walk away and freeze.

She is leaning against a white convertible in a white sundress, a broad brimmed hat with gold lining on her head. Her shoulders could balance the world and her legs go on for days. Her smile is shy, her hands splayed on the hood of the car either side of her. I walk towards her slowly, trying to get my breath under control.

“You set me up.”

She shrugs, “I saved your life.”

“You got in deep, kid, nearly got burned.”

Her hum is infuriating, “Yeah.”

“Why’d you do it? It was dangerous and stupid and…”

“For you.”

“That’s a crock you can sell to someone else and…”

“Catra, shut up.”

And then she’s in my space again, arms over my shoulders. Her eyes bore into mine. I open my mouth to protest and one hand comes back around to press a finger to my lips.

“You were right, all those years ago. We couldn’t fight the system. It was too broken. So… after I thought about it, we tried to game the system. But it got away, got dangerous. And… I got you into trouble. And I couldn’t have that. No one hurts you. No one.”

“You did. You left.”

“And you didn’t follow me. So, who’s hurtin’ who, baby?” her voice is soft, soothing. It makes my heart ache. My jaw clenches. Pride - it gets me every time.

She solves that problem by pulling me close. Her lips meet mine and it’s fire all over again. This dame’s a bad idea on legs, danger

in a dress. She broke my heart and went to hell to save me. She *killed* for me.

Who could ever top that?

When we break apart, her smile is smug. I want to wipe it off her face, so I do. With another kiss. Then I level her with a glare.

"What's with the wheels?"

"You like my Swiftwind? Let's just say I got some dividends from that whole Prime incident. All above board. We didn't launder, bought it all legally."

"After you drove down the prices."

"In a town where law means nothing, when you're taking that money from the scum who rise to the top, you think it matters? Anyway, I also have a sack of cash from Hordak's stash. The idiot thought he had me so scared he let me keep the safe secure."

"That's… stealing."

Adora just shrugs. I feel guilty - something's changed, but she gives me a lopsided grin, "Baby - we've given everything to this town. I have watched you nearly die. Angella's going to build up,

impose a whole bunch of changes. The cash would go back to the banks and just… get lost in the system. I already gave most of it away before I got here. Lots of windfalls in the tenements right now. Tax dollars at work. So, I took a handling fee. And the car I've had for a while."

I blow out a breath, feeling mollified. When did I get a conscience? As I meet her gaze, I realise it was her all along. Adora pulls away and steps towards the car. She turns and holds out a hand.

"Coming?"

"Where to?"

Her smile is light, free, "I hear Thaymor is good this time of year."

All stories worth telling are about a dame. You win her, you lose her, she screws you over, she saves you. I covered the bases I think. Part of me wanted to cuss her out, shout her down, stamp my feet for being played.

Pride is a harsh mistress.

But I'm not *always* about the bad ideas. Sometimes we do learn from our mistakes. And maybe, just maybe, those angels put us on the right path. So I take her hand.s

“Well, looks like I’m going your way Princess.”

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